

ESSENTIAL SKILL

Light, Power & Communication

See. Charge. Listen. Stay Connected.

When electricity goes out, lights, phones, internet, refrigeration, heating controls, medical devices, and communication systems can fail together. A layered backup plan can make a major difference.

HAVE MORE THAN ONE WAY TO SEE, POWER, AND COMMUNICATE.

WHEN THE POWER FAILS

Stabilize the first ten minutes

1

Turn on a flashlight or headlamp before moving through dark rooms.

2

Check for immediate hazards, medical-device needs, official alerts, and extreme indoor temperatures.

3

Keep refrigerator and freezer doors closed.

4

Disconnect sensitive electronics if surges are possible, and begin conserving phone power.

5

Tell household members what happened, where supplies are, and when the next update will be.

LIGHT COMES FIRST

Make safe movement possible

Keep flashlights, headlamps, lanterns, and matching spare batteries easy to reach. Headlamps leave both hands free for stairs, repairs, first aid, and carrying supplies.

LOCATION ONE

Beside each bed

Reach it before standing in the dark.

LOCATION TWO

Near main exits

Find shoes, keys, and a safe way out.

Battery-powered lights are generally safer than candles. Never leave any open flame unattended or burning while people sleep.

A DISCHARGED BACKUP IS NOT A BACKUP

Keep phones and batteries ready

☐ Correct charging cables

☐ Charged power banks

☐ Vehicle charger

☐ Rechargeable batteries

☐ Battery charger

☐ Solar charger where practical

Set a recharge routine

Check power banks and rechargeable batteries on a repeating calendar date. Label each with its cable, capacity, and last-check date.

SAVE POWER BEFORE YOU NEED IT

Conserve limited battery power

Reserve the phone for emergency calls, important texts, weather, official alerts, maps, and essential coordination.

- Lower screen brightness.
- Use low-power mode.
- Stop video streaming.
- Close unnecessary apps.
- Disable unneeded background activity.
- Use airplane mode when no connection is needed.

Generator safety

At least 20 feet outdoors

Keep generators away from windows, doors, attached garages, and other building openings. Point exhaust away from occupied buildings.

GENERATOR PLACEMENT

Occupied building
Keep openings closed
nearby

At least 20 feet
Exhaust points away →

Generator
Outdoors and dry

- ✗ Run a generator inside a house, garage, basement, shed, or carport.
- ✗ Connect it directly to household wiring without approved transfer equipment installed by a qualified electrician.
- ✗ Operate it in rain, flooding, or other wet conditions.
- ✗ Refuel a hot or running generator.

✗ Use it without working carbon-monoxide alarms.

Read the manual, calculate loads, store fuel safely, and practice operation before an emergency.

RUN WHAT MATTERS MOST

Decide what truly needs power

1 Essential medical equipment

2 Communication and official information

3 Critical medicine or food refrigeration

4 Safe lighting

5 Small necessary devices

Record each device's wattage, plug type, battery runtime, and backup method. A generator or battery station must never be overloaded.

Have a battery or hand-crank radio

A radio can carry weather warnings, evacuation instructions, and local emergency information. Keep compatible spare batteries beside it.

Write down local stations now

WEATHER RADIO

LOCAL AM

LOCAL FM

COUNTY ALERTS

DO NOT STORE EVERYTHING IN ONE PHONE

Keep important information offline

☐ Family phone numbers

☐ Emergency contacts

☐ Doctors and pharmacy

☐ Important addresses

☐ Local map

☐ Evacuation routes

☐ Medical information

☐ Emergency procedures

☐ Water-treatment instructions

☐ Shelter locations

A printed page still works when the internet does not.

Meeting and contact plan

Choose one familiar meeting place near home and a second place outside the immediate area. Select a trusted out-of-area contact who can receive each person’s location and status.

Household communication card

NEARBY
MEETING

AREA MEETING

OUT-OF-AREA
CONTACT

CONTACT
NUMBER

BACKUP NUMBER

LOCAL
EMERGENCY

Print a copy for each person’s wallet, bag, or coat and post one at home. Review it whenever information changes.

KEEP MESSAGES SHORT AND USEFUL

Texting may work when calls do not

During network congestion, texts may go through when voice calls do not, although delivery can be delayed. Limit non-emergency calls and do not repeatedly redial.

SAFE. AT HOME. EVERYONE OK.

LEAVING NOW. GOING TO MEETING PLACE 2.

NEED HELP. AT [LOCATION]. [SHORT PROBLEM].

Call 911 only for emergencies. Do not text or operate a phone while driving.

SIMPLE AND VERIFIED INFORMATION

Community communication

Establish one known information point: a bulletin board, central room, designated radio operator, or scheduled briefing location.

☐ Everyone knows where verified updates are posted.

☐ One person or small team confirms information before sharing it.

☐ The next update time is clearly posted.

☐ People know how to report injuries, hazards, shortages, and missing persons.

☐ Old notices are dated and removed to prevent confusion.

RECOMMENDED SUPPLIES

Simple light and communication kit

☐ Flashlights

☐ Headlamps

☐ Lanterns

☐ Spare batteries

☐ Rechargeable batteries

☐ Battery chargers

☐ Charged power banks

☐ Correct charging cables

☐ Vehicle charger

☐ Solar charger if appropriate

☐ Battery or hand-crank radio

☐ Printed contact plan

☐ Printed local map

☐ Emergency instructions

☐ Permanent marker

☐ Notebook and pencils

Label chargers, battery banks, radios, and cables. Store matched equipment together rather than keeping a box of unidentified cords.

AVOID THESE

Common mistakes

✗ Depend on one flashlight or one charging method.

✗ Leave spare batteries untested and power banks discharged.

✗ Depend entirely on cell phones or the internet.

✗ Run a generator indoors or near building openings.

✗ Waste limited power on nonessential entertainment.

✗ Keep important contacts only in a phone.

✗ Assume family members know where to meet.

✗ Spread information that has not been verified.

TRY THIS NOW

One-hour power-outage practice

One evening, turn off normal lights for one hour without disabling safety systems or essential equipment.

1. Have everyone find a working light.
2. Check batteries and charge a phone from backup power.
3. Tune the radio to a known local station.
4. Use the printed contact and meeting plan.
5. Identify which equipment truly requires electricity.
6. Test one short status message to the out-of-area contact.

Correct anything that was difficult to find, discharged, unlabeled, or unknown.

BEFORE AN EMERGENCY

Quick checklist

☐ I have working lights beside beds and near exits.

☐ I have tested spare batteries and charged power banks.

☐ I have more than one phone-charging method.

☐ I have a working radio and know local stations.

☐ Important contacts and instructions exist on paper.

☐ Everyone knows both meeting locations.

☐ We have an out-of-area contact.

☐ I have listed equipment that needs priority power.

☐ I know how to operate any generator safely.

REMEMBER

Light helps people move safely. Power should be saved for what matters most.

Communication should never depend on only one system.

SEE. CHARGE. LISTEN. STAY CONNECTED.

Official guidance and planning tools

Follow local emergency alerts, equipment manuals, and utility instructions during an actual outage.

Ready.gov: Power Outages(<https://www.ready.gov/power-outages>)

Ready.gov: Family Emergency
Communication Plan

(<https://www.ready.gov/sites/default/files/2020-03/family-emergency-communication-planning-document.pdf>)

FCC and FEMA: Emergency Communication Tips(<https://www.fcc.gov/emergency>)
